Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Watchtower

1.1.11 Watchtower

References:

Hebrew מִגְדָּל (migdal) GEN 35:21, 2CH 26:10, ISA 5:2, MIC 4:8

Greek πύργος (purgos) MAT 21:33, MRK 12:1, LUK 14:28

Description and usage:

The watchtower was a structure made of stone, sometimes round but more often rectangular. It was normally built on a high place in or near a vineyard. It stood 2–5 meters (6–16 feet) high and was mounted by a ladder or steps. During the grape harvest, it was the custom for the owner of a vineyard or one of his family members or servants to spend the night on the watchtower to guard against animals or thieves who might try to steal the grapes. Similar towers could also be built to watch over other property, such as sheep and goats.

Translation:

English uses basically the same expression to describe this structure in a farmer's field and a lookout point on a city wall (see 3.13.3.3 Watchtower, tower<REALIA:3.13.3.3>). In some languages, however, the two structures may have very different terms. In a few verses (for example, 1CH 27:25; 2CH 26:10; SIR 37:14), it is not entirely clear from the context which type of tower is intended; in GEN 35:21 and MIC 4:8 the reference may be to either one, or it may even be a place name.

Some translators may want to use a descriptive phrase for "watchtower," for example, "tower to keep watch over the vineyard" (PV; MAT 21:33).